

Psalms 10

When God Seems Far

Why standest thou afar off, O Lord?

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Why standest thou afar off, O LORD? why hidest thou thyself in times of trouble?*
- 2 *The wicked in his pride doth persecute the poor: let them be taken in the devices that they have imagined.*
- 3 *For the wicked boasteth of his heart's desire, and blesseth the covetous, whom the LORD abhorreth.*
- 4 *The wicked, through the pride of his countenance, will not seek after God: God is not in all his thoughts.*
- 5 *His ways are always grievous; thy judgments are far above out of his sight: as for all his enemies, he puffeth at them.*
- 6 *He hath said in his heart, I shall not be moved: for I shall never be in adversity.*
- 7 *His mouth is full of cursing and deceit and fraud: under his tongue is mischief and vanity.*
- 8 *He sitteth in the lurking places of the villages: in the secret places doth he murder the innocent: his eyes are privily set against the poor.*
- 9 *He lieth in wait secretly as a lion in his den: he lieth in wait to catch the poor: he doth catch the poor, when he draweth him into his net.*
- 10 *He croucheth, and humbleth himself, that the poor may fall by his strong ones.*
- 11 *He hath said in his heart, God hath forgotten: he hideth his face; he will never see it.*
- 12 *Arise, O LORD; O God, lift up thine hand: forget not the humble.*
- 13 *Wherefore doth the wicked contemn God? he hath said in his heart, Thou wilt not require it.*
- 14 *Thou hast seen it; for thou beholdest mischief and spite, to requite it with thy hand: the poor committeth himself unto thee; thou art the helper of the fatherless.*
- 15 *Break thou the arm of the wicked and the evil man: seek out his wickedness till thou find none.*
- 16 *The LORD is King for ever and ever: the heathen are perished out of his land.*
- 17 *LORD, thou hast heard the desire of the humble: thou wilt prepare their heart, thou wilt cause thine ear to hear:*
- 18 *To judge the fatherless and the oppressed, that the man of the earth may no more oppress.*

2 · CONTEXT

A lament over the proud wicked who prey on the poor and assume God does not see. Often read with Psalm 9. Henry notes the psalm's honest protest ("Why hidest thou?") and its movement to confidence that God has seen, hears the humble, and will judge. It gives language for times when evil seems unchecked.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-4

Complaint: God seems distant in trouble. The wicked proudly persecute the poor, boast desires, bless greed, and refuse to seek God—"God is not in all his thoughts." Practical atheism fuels oppression.

Verse 5-11

Portrait of the oppressor: secure, sneering at enemies, sure he will never be moved; mouth full of cursing and deceit; ambush of the innocent like a lion; heart says God has forgotten and will never see.

Verse 12-15

Petition: arise, lift Your hand, forget not the humble. The wicked contemn God, saying He will not require account. Faith answers: You have seen; You will requite; the poor commit themselves to You, helper of the fatherless. Break the arm of the wicked.

Verse 16-18

Confession: the Lord is King forever. He has heard the humble's desire, prepares their heart, hears, and judges for the fatherless and oppressed so earthly man may no more oppress.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Felt divine absence is part of faithful prayer, not its opposite. God sees mischief the wicked deny; He is King; He hears the humble and defends the fatherless. Oppression’s swagger is temporary under His reign.

Application for life today.

When God feels far, use verse 1 rather than silent despair. Name modern “lurking places” of exploitation and pray verse 12–15. Commit the vulnerable (and yourself when vulnerable) to the helper of the fatherless. Let the King’s forever-reign correct both cynicism and passivity.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where does it currently feel as if God is “afar off”—and can you bring that question to Him as the psalmist does?

2. How does the portrait of the wicked (pride, greed, “God won’t see”) confront your culture or your own heart?

3. What would it mean to “commit” a burden or a vulnerable person to the Lord this week (v. 14)?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).